SpeechGeek




Season Three: Fall 2005

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# Season Three: Fall 2005

**SpeechGeek**
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One of our goals in publishing **SpeechGeek** is to introduce the forensic world to new and talented writers. Traditional publishers often neglect promising writers. Other publishers are often clueless as to the needs of forensics performers. The material found in **SpeechGeek** is written by veteran and new forensic students and coaches. We strive to provide a product that is fresh and challenges the conventions of what makes a great performance. The most rewarding part of this process is that the material is left in your hands to make the final decision. You get to explore the emotions, characters, and stories. We may provide the material, but the end result is completely up to you. **Season Three starts here and what a season it will be!**

**Corey Alderdice**
**Publisher**




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# Pipe Dreams

by Andy Birge

**NARR.** In a time long past, there once lived a man and his brother with the ability to make right where there was once wrong, peace where there was chaos, and nothing where there was once spaghetti. These that I speak of are the brothers Mario...

**LUIGI.** Wait! Why does it have to be all about Mario? Mario....Mario...Mario...

**NARR.** But isn't your last name Mario?

**LUIGI.** Well...yeah, but I mean...WHAT KIND OF NAME IS MARIO MARIO ANYWAY? (*turns away sobbing*)

*(Toadstool wanders into the room.)*

**TOAD.** Hhhheeey guys...you got any candy? (*staggers*)

**LUIGI.** What's up Toadstool? Look at me. Let me see your eyes. Are you drunk again?

**TOAD.** Yeah. So?

**LUIGI.** SO, it's 9:30 in the morning.

**TOAD.** Hey, let me tell you something, I love you man...No, I mean it...I really love you man...(*mumbles off*)

**LUIGI.** Have you paid the utilities yet?

**NARR.** Like I was saying before, the Mario Brothers have revolutionized our world as well as the Mushroom Kingdom. I am here today with Luigi Mario, faithful sidekick and brother to the world famous Mario Mario. So, Luigi, I see that you have gained a few pounds since we last saw you. What happened?

**LUIGI.** Well, mainly, I was tired of maintaining my image. After our life story was made into a movie, my reputation was ruined. I attribute the fall of my career to John Leguizamo. Hollywood wanted to make me seem like the pansy sidekick. Back in the day, I ran the game.

**NARR.** So, what have you and the crew been up to over the past fifteen years?

**LUIGI.** Well, Mario and I don't speak much since the plumbing business went down the drain. No pun intended. Since he went on the Atkin's diet, he thinks he's too good for me, rolling in royalties and spaghetti sauce. He doesn't eat the noodles anymore, though—or the mushrooms.

**NARR.** No mushrooms?

**LUIGI.** Well, the mushrooms from the Kingdom are *really* high in carbs. Haven't you seen that fool? He's emaciated, but he still has the best parties, I'll give him that. Everyone's there...me and Toad, the Princess, all the goombas, Bowser...

**NARR.** Bowser?

**LUIGI.** Oh, Bowser gave up his life of crime long ago when he married. It's shunned upon and everything--marrying outside of the game. It's an issue to some, but I don't care.

*(Cut to interview with Bowser, AKA King Koopa.)*

**BOWSER.** There is only one way. We must find the light that lies within us in order to find our ultimate purpose. Isn't that right, honey?

**WIFE.** Of course, Bowzie.

**NARR.** So tell me, how did you meet?

**BOWSER.** Well, one day I was at the bottom of a castle throwing fireballs at tourists and I realized I was missing something. A hole that no fireball could fill: the hole of true love. In the past, every woman I abducted was rescued, but this time, I knew she would rescue me.

**NARR.** So....*how* did you meet?

# Inside a Specimen Box

by Jacob Alcantar

**Author's Notes:**

*This play is intended to be a drama that asks the audience to think about the transitory relationships we have with people, and how our lives are shaped by the " boxes" we are put in, and the people we come across. In other words, it is a play that follows the life of an individual who becomes a professor of entomology because of his/her specific life circumstances. I say his/her for the specific reason that, while the monologue was intended for a male, it is perfectly understandable for a female to play the role and the necessary pronoun changes to be made in the script.*

*The characters are meant to be vividly humorous, brief, and are meant to give the audience the impression that, while they took part in a relatively small part in the professor's life, they had a significant affect on the person he becomes. The characters should be introduced and executed quickly, as if their voices and postures are merely characters in the memory of the professor; as if they are concomitant memories or thoughts happening in the professor's head as he is speaking. Their humor is tp be accentuated as this allows for peaks and troughs and amplifies the drama of the piece.*

*The professor must address the audience as if they were his/her students in a lecture hall or classroom and must make subtle swallowing noises or expressions. All other stage directions should be taken as notes within the script and are just good ideas, but a unique interpretation is, by all means encouraged. It is vital, however, that the audience is addressed as students. This makes each member of the audience a character in the play with their own personal relationship and reactions to the professor. Eye contact, and a believable, multidimensional, and a tragically real main character is a must.*

*Otherwise, this piece is meant to be interpreted to the hearts content. It should be stated that cutting and adding the necessary remedies to make the story personalized and personal for both the actors wishing to utilize the script and the audience are welcomed. The actors wishing to utilize the script should not preoccupy themselves too much with the stage directions, but should ask themselves and ask their audience as best they can: "Where, exactly, shall we begin?"*

The Schmidt Pain Index was developed by an entomologist whom wished to categorize the amount of pain an insect could render upon the human body. The scale ranges from a one to a four. One being the most painless, four being the most painful. Welcome to the world of entomology. This classroom, like life, is often hard and tedious work. Some days in here will be a one on the pain scale, but some might be closer to a four. So, for today, I would like to get personal; tell you why I do what I do; tell you all about myself. And the first thing I will tell you about myself...(*The professor holds up his specimen box and a pair of tweezers)*...is that I consider all of my students to be specimens.

I have only two memories from my childhood. One is being bitten by some kind of bug on my left cheekbone after playing in a truck trailer full of poinsettias. And one is of Mrs. Russo, the old Jewish woman from the apartment next door, having and an arthritis attack while scrubbing my vomit out of the carpet. *(He puts the box and the tweezers down.)* A child's fever and vomiting and an old woman's arthritis attack. Schmidt Pain Index number one.

***(As Mrs. Russo)***

'The best thing I can tell you is to learn how to count it...*(While she speaks she is preoccupied with scrubbing vomit out of the carpet, but she is also trying to watch television and comfort the professor at the same time. Her hands let the audience*

*know that she is in pain from her arthritis.)*...the pain that is. Low numbers means it's coming on...high numbers means you just gotta believe that it's going away...That's all. No really, that's all. Now get out of my way will you, I've been cleaning up your barf for half an hour and I'm going to miss the end of my soap opera...'

(*Chuckling slightly to himself.)* That was what Mrs. Russo told me that once when I was very sick. You see, Mrs. Russo was the closest thing to a grandmother that I had, and I suppose I was the closest thing she had to a son, I mean, after her real son died in Vietnam. She once gave me a little black box that his war medals were originally kept in...*(He holds up the box to insure that the audience knows that the box he is referring to is the box directly in front of him)...*and told me it was only meant hold remnants of things that had died, so I've kept dead bugs in it ever since. I even took it with me in my mother's big rig truck that summer after I graduated high school. Now I spent *every* summer in my mother's big rig truck, so at first I didn't want to go, but my mother said she had something important to tell me once we got to Michigan. Besides, I had grown accustomed to stopping at a small pink motel called the Flora Rosada in a remote town somewhere in southeast New Mexico near Mexican border. The owner let my mother park her truck in the parking lot there. He was a nice guy who had a son with some type of skin disorder and he always did our laundry but I never knew why.

***(As the owner of the Flora Rosada)***

*'Here's the laundry. Tell your mother she doesn't have to leave any money, but I could use a few dollars to buy Leroy some more bleach, you know for his skin. Doctors in Santa Fe said to give him warm baths with a little bit of bleach in it or else his skin will get all infected cause he ain't got enough collagen and that's why his skin melts off like it does. Anyway I used the last little bit of the bleach I had washin' your clothes cause they smelled like ass...(spit)...phalt. Asphalt. But your mother always said that was just the smell of the road.'*

But even on the sweltering summer days like that one; like the one's when I spent hours in the pool in the middle of the parking lot waiting for the owner of the Flora Rosada to back the wash, that boy just stayed up inside room fourteen and peered down at me with his pale white face with open wounds and thin silver glasses like a ghost. I often wondered if he ever got to come outside. I wondered if he ever got to enjoy the sun; if he ever got to cross the skinny highway that ran past the motel like I did in order to talk to the one-eyed Indian Chief who owned the gas station next to the bar.

***(As the one-eyed Indian Chief)***

'I seen you out there in that pool across the street; I seen you out in the heat in that pool all day. You whacked out on pey-o-te? *(Pause.)* No stupid, not coy-o-te...*(Howls)*...I'm talking about peyote...you know...*(The chief makes an inhaling/slurping gesture and howls again, except more wildly and as if under the influence of a hallucinogen)*...peyote. *(Pause.)* Well, good. It's a good thing you don't have any idea of what I'm talking about. You're a good boy. You stay away from peyote—and those men at the bar—bad medicine.'

But my mother went into the bar all the time. Some nights, she'd put on a dress with a million octagonal blue sequins-looked like flies eyes-and on those nights there wasn't a place to park for miles and, though I was never allowed inside myself on those nights, I could always hear that bar brim-full of drunk happy men singing:

***(As a Drunken Truck Driver)***

' Take a load off Fanny...*(He burps on cue to the rhythm of the song, grabs another beer.)*...take a load for free; take a load off Fanny...*( Takes money out of his pocket.)*...and (and) you can put the load right on me.' *(As he finishes he stuffs the money into his pants above his crotch, or into someone else's waste line insinuating that 'Take a load of Fanny,' the professor's mother, is an exotic dancer or stripper. This should be slightly humorous as to add to the dramatic effect of the professor's next lines.)*

That song meant that my mother would have a little extra money, if you know what I mean, so we could afford to the pay the man whom owned the trailer on the

outskirts of town to climb up on a little step ladder and wash our windshields before we started off to Michigan in the morning.

***(As the Window Washer)***

*(The entire time the window washer is speaking it should appear as if Jesus is a voice in the man's head. He should be leaning over slightly, as if leaning over the hood of a car, and he should be drying off an imaginary windshield between himself and the audience. As he speaks he addresses Fanny, the professor's mother, and the professor himself. This character should give the audience the humorous impression that he may be slightly crazy, but good-hearted. The audience should get the impression that the professor's mother may not exactly have any extra money to spend but does so because she takes pity upon a man who has so little, but believes so vehemently in Jesus and does such a good job washing windows.)* 'Jesus wanted me to tell you that you looked mighty pretty last night, Fanny. You know who Jesus was don't you boy? He was a window washer who washed all the sin from our souls so we could see the light. But it looks like you seen too much light young man. You've been swimming down in the pool down at the Flora Rosada again haven't you? You do that to yourself every year don't you? I knew it. Jesus knows it too. Jesus! You got sunburn something awful. Put some raw meat on it Fanny, it takes away the sting. Well I think I'm done here...Jesus says you can pay me my money please...now...'

I imagine that the boy in the window had skin that felt like mine that morning we left; that morning that our windshields were wiped clean for the last time. My skin felt so awful. It was an itchy, burning, lasting type of pain. Schmidt Pain Index number two.

And that pain lasted all the way to Michigan. It was twilight. We had just crossed the state line when I begged my mother to let me roll down the window. I knew it would be very cold but that's what my skin wanted. So I rolled down the window and the wind was crisp and cold on my skin. And then... *(The most effective way of conveying this scene is to have the professor snap his fingers out in front of him as if bugs were hitting the windshield. Before the first 'SPLAT' there should only be a few snaps, before the second 'SPLAT' there should be more snaps, and before the third there should be many quick snaps as to convey an increase in the number of bugs flying into the windshield)...*SPLAT... SPLAT...on the windshield and then OUCH...(*He touches his face)*...something flew into me...then OUCH. OWE. OWE! There must have been millions of them coming out of the ground, flying across the highway so fast that they were jetting in through the open window and stinging our faces and stinging my sunburn and then jittering all over us in our clothes and hair. Then all of a sudden I look over at my mother and she's pulling the horn. WOO WOO. Wham. One car. Wham. Two cars. Wham. Wham. Wham. Blackout. When I opened my eyes there were lights and sirens and my mother's legs are all tangled up in the springs of the seat while her upper body was impaled on the jagged leftovers of the windshield. Some of the bugs were stuck twitching in congealed blood spread across the dashboard. And I just wanted to smash them for what they had done when I realized that my skin didn't hurt...I was covered in blood and hundreds, maybe thousands of cold twitching exoskeletons. I just felt so good; so good and so cold. That's when I realized that somehow, through the whole crash, I had managed to reach down, grab hold of, and hold onto the little black box that had been sitting beside the seat that Mrs. Russo had given me all those years ago.

*(The professor should be very emotional by this point and should be to the verge of tears or crying while trying to maintain composure as he says his next lines. After the next lines his sadness should appear to be suppressed until the final lines allow him to be extremely emotional again. This will allow the audience to understand the details of the story pertinent to their understanding.)* My mother's death, and, ironically, the moment I became an entomologist. Schmidt Pain Index number three.

*(This scene should be acted out as if the professor was reliving the moment.)* We buried her in a simple dirt mound off of a dirt road behind the Flora Rosada. The Chief from the station performed some type of ceremony with a handful of feathers and a jumbo-sized coffee can. I was kneeling in the dust crying and the chief was chanting

when I heard a rumble in the distance and turned... And there was the owner of the Flora Rosada rolling a frail little boy all covered in bandages up the dirt road towards my mother's grave. And behind them, the window washer was walking along talking to Jesus, and behind him Mrs. Russo, old as she was, pioneered her dusty car up the dirt road. But behind her-and I'll never forget it-was a convoy of shiny big rig trucks as far as the eye could see. One by one the truckers parked, paid their respects, and put one hundred dollars each into the coffee can atop my mother's grave. By the end of the day I counted 131 truckers that had come to say goodbye to 'take a load off Fanny' and by the end of the day there was exactly thirteen thousand one hundred dollars, a hand full of feathers, and one pink poinsettia in that coffee can. I was so busy talking to strange truckers about my mother was 'really somethin' else' and how every year she had given them a little something to look forward to and how word travels fast along CB radios that I never saw who left the pink poinsettia. When all the truckers were gone, I offered a portion of the money to Mrs. Russo, to the Chief, to the window washer and to the owner and his son...no one would take it...though I did manage to slip close to two thousand in the bandages on the boy's forearm...for bleach I guess.

I took the rest of the money and came here, to the university, to become an entomologist, to figure out how such little things could have such a big impact on people's lives. As an entomologist I learned that the bugs that killed my mother were Cicada bugs, native to that area of Michigan. They come out from underground and swarm only once every 17 years in order to mate. But my all-time favorite is this little bug: the South American Kissing Beetle or 'vinchuca.' It often lives amongst plants and flowers. It carries Chagas' disease. It bites you on your face, feeds on your blood and then defecates in the wound passing on a trypanosome that causes occasional vomiting and fever in children. The disease becomes dormant for fifteen to thirty years until victims die of an enlarged heart, cardiac arrest, an enlarged lower digestive system, and inability to swallow. There is no cure for Chagas's disease and there has been only one known victim in the United States. You're looking at him.

When I found out I was going to die I wanted to know if I had family. Turns out I did...in New Mexico. But when I went back, it was a ghost town. Local authorities said that one day my father had walked down stairs to bring up a fresh load of laundry and when he returned he found my brother floating face down in a bathtub full of bloody bleach water so he hung himself from the second story balcony.

You see, when I first really put it all together I was performing undergraduate research on the bot-fly which infests the cattle in Mexico. While I was in Mexico there was this little old Mexican woman, *a vendedora de floras*, selling pink flowers on a street corner, and do you know what she called them? *Floras rosadas.* Flora Rosada is Spanish for *pink flower.* Then it all came flickering to light like a big pink neon sign right out of the middle of nowhere.

You see, there once was a woman who was a truck driver who married a man who bought a pink motel and named it after the flowers the woman imported from Mexico and hauled to Michigan. The woman liked to put on sequined dresses and let drunken truckers feel her up for money and was terrible at doing laundry and the man had the disgusting habit of chewing tobacco and cussing and always letting their eldest son play in the woman's truck trailer even though she hated it. The younger son was unable to play in the truck, or even go outside because he was born with a rare skin disorder. So when the two boys were very young the two filed for irreconcilable differences. The woman believed in the spirit and the open road and the man believed in science and the home so each of them took a son and made a point of seeing each other once a year in order to see which of them was being a better parent. But it didn't matter because everyone eventually ended up dead.

A family full of dead people. The fact that some species are just supposed to die out. That, is Schmidt Pain Index number *four.*

Perhaps my mother wanted to tell me who my father was once we got into Michigan, but God only knows. And sometimes I wonder, you know, if God is just some sort of cosmic entomologist who just lets us crawl all over one another in this little black specimen box we call the universe until he shakes us up a bit or until we get squished or until we find a little hole of light and fly towards it with all of ourselves. I often wonder

who the *real* insects are*. (He swallows hard and presses his fingers into his throat.)* But, I still have time to answer these questions, and you still have time to learn. And you may be asking yourselves why I have been so open, and you may be saying to yourselves now 'maybe this is the wrong place for me,' but if you have any inclinations like that than do yourselves a favor and see yourselves to the door. Some days will be a one, and some days will be closer to a four. Low numbers means it's coming on and high numbers means you just have to believe that it's going away. But for those of you who have the will to stick with this class, and stick with me, and all that we entail, the rewards will be immense. Because there are many bugs in this box*...(He gestures to the specimen box)...*and in this box*...(He gestures to the classroom)...*and in this one*...(He gestures to the world at large and then picks up a pair of tweezers once again and looks past them to the audience)...*so, my question to you, is:

Where, exactly, shall we begin?